Lesson 07: Semicolons, Colons and Dashes

English Stage 3 (C1) · Unit 1: Refining Sentences and Punctuation

Adapted from College ESL Writers: Applied Grammar and Composing Strategies for Success by Barbara Hall and Elizabeth Wallace, Georgia State University - Perimeter College (CC BY-NC-SA): 8.2: Semicolons; 8.3: Colons; 8.7: Dashes.

In this lesson

You will learn three marks that make a stronger break than a comma: the semicolon, which joins two closely related independent clauses or separates list items that already contain commas; the colon, which introduces a list, an example, an explanation or a quotation; and the dash, which sets off information for emphasis. Used well, they let you vary your sentences and show exactly how your ideas are connected, which readers of academic writing value.

Learning goals

After this lesson you should be able to:

- Join two closely related independent clauses with a semicolon, and avoid a semicolon before FANBOYS.
- Separate list items that contain commas with semicolons.
- Use a colon after an independent clause to introduce a list, an example, an explanation or a quotation, and decide whether the next word needs a capital letter.
- Use one dash or a pair of dashes to set off information for emphasis.
- Choose between a period, a comma, a semicolon, a colon and a dash.

Key language

Word or phrase	Meaning	Example
semicolon (;)	a mark that joins two closely related independent clauses, or separates list items that contain commas	Be sure to wear clean, well-pressed clothes to the interview; appearances are important.
colon (:)	a mark after an independent clause that introduces a list, an example, an explanation or a quotation	The team will tour three states: New York, Pennsylvania, and Maryland.
dash (—)	a long line that sets off information for emphasis and shows a pause	Arrive to the interview early—but not too early.
independent clause	a subject and a verb that can stand alone as a complete thought	appearances are important

Word or phrase	Meaning	Example
closely related	the second clause explains, continues or adds to the first	"appearances are important" explains why clean clothes matter
choppy	written in many short sentences that do not flow	...to the interview. Appearances are important.
comma splice	two independent clauses joined with only a comma (the book calls it "an awkward run-on sentence")	...to the interview, appearances are important.
FANBOYS	the coordinating conjunctions for, and, nor, but, or, yet, so	(no semicolon before them)
memo	a short business message	To: Human Resources / From: Deanna Dean
proper noun	the name of a particular person, place or thing; always capitalized	Belize, Honduras, and El Salvador
emphasis	special importance given to some words	Any of the suits—except for the purple one—should be fine to wear.

Rules and explanations

Semicolons

1. Between two closely related independent clauses

	Example
Correct	Be sure to wear clean, well-pressed clothes to the interview; appearances are important.
Choppy (correct, but less smooth)	Be sure to wear clean, well-pressed clothes to the interview. Appearances are important.
Incorrect	Be sure to wear clean, well-pressed clothes to the interview, appearances are important.

- There must be an independent clause on both sides of the semicolon.
- Do not use a semicolon with FANBOYS (and, but, or ...): use a comma there (Lesson 06).
- As in all the book's examples, the word after a semicolon has no capital letter, unless it is a name or *I*.
- A semicolon gives variety to sentence length and structure while keeping the flow of ideas.

2. Between list items that already contain commas

- The color combinations we can choose from are black, white, and grey; green, brown, and black; or red, green, and brown.

With commas only, the reader cannot see where one set of colors ends and the next begins.

Colons

Use a colon to introduce the following. The part before the colon must be an **independent clause**: a complete thought with a subject and a verb.

- a list: I have to take four classes this semester: Composition, Statistics, Ethics, and Italian.
- an example or an explanation: Our company offers many publishing services: writing, editing, and reviewing.
- a quotation: My mother loved this line from Hamlet: "To thine own self be true."

A colon also follows the greeting in a business letter and the headings of a memo: Dear Hiring Manager: / To: Human Resources / From: Deanna Dean

Do not use a colon after *such as* or *for example*. Incorrect: Our company offers many publishing services, such as: writing, editing, and reviewing.

A capital letter after a colon?

What follows the colon	Capital letter?	Example
a proper noun	yes	We visited three countries: Belize, Honduras, and El Salvador.
the beginning of a quotation	yes	My mother loved this line from Hamlet: "To thine own self be true."
an independent clause	yes (the book's rule)	There are drawbacks to modern technology: My brother's cell phone died and he lost a lot of phone numbers.
words that are not a complete sentence	no	Incorrect: The recipe is simple: Tomato, basil, and avocado. (Correct: ...simple: tomato, basil, and avocado.)

(In the third example, Lesson 06's rule also needs a comma before *and*: ...died, and he lost ...)

Usage varies: many style guides (for example the Chicago Manual of Style) use a small letter for an independent clause after a colon. APA style, used in psychology, capitalizes it, as the book does.

Dashes

A dash (—) sets off information for emphasis and shows a pause. Use one dash before information at the end of a sentence, or a pair of dashes around information in the middle.

- Arrive to the interview early—but not too early.
- Any of the suits—except for the purple one—should be fine to wear.

Do not put spaces between a dash and the words. In Microsoft Word, type two hyphens together to make a dash. A dash is longer than a hyphen (-) and has a different job (Lesson 08). **Usage varies:** British texts often use a shorter dash with a space on each side (–).

Choosing the mark

You want to ...	Use
join two closely related independent clauses with no conjunction	a semicolon
join two independent clauses with FANBOYS	a comma + FANBOYS
introduce a list, an example, an explanation or a quotation after a complete sentence	a colon
separate list items that contain commas	semicolons
add information with emphasis, or show a sudden pause	one dash or two dashes

> **Note for Arabic speakers**
>
> - Arabic usually puts a colon after "he said" before the words someone said. In English, use a comma after *said* or *asked* (Lesson 06). Use a colon before a quotation only when a complete sentence comes before it: My mother loved this line from Hamlet: "To thine own self be true."

Practice

The exercises in the lesson material have no numbers; here they are numbered in the order they appear.

Exercise 1. Semicolons. Correct the sentences by adding semicolons. If a sentence is correct, write OK.

1. I did not notice that you were in the office I was behind the front desk all day.
2. Do you want turkey, spinach, and cheese roast beef, lettuce, and cheese or ham, tomato, and cheese?
3. Please close the blinds there is a glare on the screen.
4. Unbelievably, no one was hurt in the accident.
5. I cannot decide if I want my room to be green, brown, and purple green, black, and brown or green, brown, and dark red.
6. Let's go for a walk the air is so refreshing.

Exercise 2. Semicolons and colons. Add semicolons or colons where needed. If a sentence needs neither, write OK.

1. Don't give up you never know what tomorrow brings.
2. Our records show that the patient was admitted on March 9, 2010 January 13, 2010 and November 16, 2009.
3. Allow me to introduce myself I am the greatest ice-carver in the world.
4. Where I come from there are three ways to get to the grocery store by car, by bus, and by foot.
5. Listen closely you will want to remember this speech.
6. I have lived in Sedona, Arizona Baltimore, Maryland and Knoxville, Tennessee.

7. The boss's message was clear Lateness would not be tolerated.
8. Next semester, we will read some more contemporary authors, such as Vonnegut, Miller, … (The end of this sentence is missing in the lesson material.)
9. My little sister said what we were all thinking "We should have stayed home."
10. Trust me I have done this before.

Exercise 3. Dashes. Make the sentences clearer by adding dashes. If a sentence is clear as it is, write OK.

1. Which hairstyle do you prefer short or long?
2. I don't know I hadn't even thought about that.
3. Guess what I got the job!
4. I will be happy to work over the weekend if I can have Monday off.
5. You have all the qualities that we are looking for in a candidate intelligence, dedication, and a strong work ethic.

Speak with your tutor

- "Give me ten pairs of related sentences about stress and coping. For each pair, I will choose a semicolon, a colon, a comma + FANBOYS, or two sentences, and explain why. Then tell me if my choices are right."
- "Here are three versions of one of my sentences, with a semicolon, a colon and a dash: [paste]. How does the meaning or emphasis change?"
- "Here is a paragraph I wrote for my psychology course: [paste]. Show me two places where a semicolon, a colon or a dash would connect my ideas more clearly. Do not rewrite the whole paragraph."
- "Quiz me: give me five sentences with a colon, some correct and some not (for example a colon after *such as*). I will find and fix the wrong ones."

Read aloud

Pause and take a breath at a semicolon; pause at a colon and before and after dashes.

1. Be sure to wear clean, well-pressed clothes to the interview; appearances are important.
2. The color combinations we can choose from are black, white, and grey; green, brown, and black; or red, green, and brown.
3. The team will tour three states: New York, Pennsylvania, and Maryland.
4. My mother loved this line from Hamlet: "To thine own self be true."
5. Arrive to the interview early—but not too early.
6. Any of the suits—except for the purple one—should be fine to wear.

Writing task

Write a paragraph of 150 to 200 words on one of these topics:

- advice for someone going to a job interview or starting at a university, with reasons (like the book's interview examples);
- a topic from PSYC 110, for example three ways people cope with stress, or what helps us remember new information.

Include: two semicolons that join closely related independent clauses; one list with semicolons between items that contain commas (for example cities and countries, or researchers and their universities); one colon that introduces a list; one colon that introduces an explanation or a quotation; and one dash or a pair of dashes.

Checklist:

- Each semicolon has an independent clause on both sides.
- There is no semicolon before *and*, *but*, *or*, *so* or another FANBOYS word.
- I used semicolons in a list only where the items already contain commas.
- A complete sentence comes before every colon; there is no colon after *such as* or *for example*.
- After each colon, I used a capital letter for a proper noun, a quotation or an independent clause, and a small letter for words that are not a complete sentence.
- My dashes have no spaces around them, and they mark information I want to emphasize.
- I did not use a hyphen (-) where I needed a dash (—).

Paste your draft into the chat and ask your tutor for feedback. Then rewrite it.

Answer key

The book gives no key; these answers follow the book's rules.

Exercise 1

1. I did not notice that you were in the office; I was behind the front desk all day.
2. Do you want turkey, spinach, and cheese; roast beef, lettuce, and cheese; or ham, tomato, and cheese?
3. Please close the blinds; there is a glare on the screen.
4. OK
5. ...green, brown, and purple; green, black, and brown; or green, brown, and dark red.
6. Let's go for a walk; the air is so refreshing.

Exercise 2

1. Don't give up; you never know what tomorrow brings. (A colon is also possible, because the second clause explains the first: Don't give up: You never know ...)
2. ...admitted on March 9, 2010; January 13, 2010; and November 16, 2009.
3. Allow me to introduce myself: I am the greatest ice-carver in the world. (The second part is the introduction, so a colon is best; a semicolon is also correct.)
4. Where I come from, there are three ways to get to the grocery store: by car, by bus, and by foot. (The comma after *from* ends the introductory clause; it is correct but not part of this exercise.)
5. Listen closely; you will want to remember this speech. (A colon is also possible: Listen closely: You will want ...)
6. I have lived in Sedona, Arizona; Baltimore, Maryland; and Knoxville, Tennessee.
7. The boss's message was clear: Lateness would not be tolerated.
8. OK. Do not put a colon after *such as*.
9. My little sister said what we were all thinking: "We should have stayed home."
10. Trust me; I have done this before. (A colon is also possible: Trust me: I have done this before.)

Exercise 3

1. Which hairstyle do you prefer—short or long?
2. I don't know—I hadn't even thought about that.
3. Guess what—I got the job!
4. OK. (A dash is possible if you want to stress the condition: ...over the weekend—if I can have Monday off.)
5. ...we are looking for in a candidate—intelligence, dedication, and a strong work ethic. (A colon is also correct, because the list follows an independent clause.)

My notes